Semantics

Marc Alexander · Week 7

Who decides what a word means?

1. Is a Jaffa Cake a cake or a biscuit?

- In the UK, cakes are zero-rated for VAT; chocolate-covered biscuits are taxed at the standard rate
- McVitie's argued before a VAT tribunal in 1991 that Jaffa Cakes are cakes
  - A cake goes hard when it is stale; a biscuit goes soft
  - McVitie's baked a giant Jaffa Cake for the tribunal to make the point
- The tribunal agreed: a Jaffa Cake is a cake, and carries no VAT[1]

2. Is Subway's bread *bread*?

- Irish VAT law zero-rates bread, defined as containing sugar or fat of no more than 2% of the weight of the flour
- Subway's rolls contained sugar at about 10% of the weight of the flour
- The Irish Supreme Court ruled in 2020 that they are not "bread" for VAT purposes, so they are taxed[2]

3. Is a burrito a sandwich?

- Panera Bread's lease at a shopping centre in Massachusetts barred the landlord from renting to another restaurant selling more than 10% sandwiches
- The landlord then rented a unit to Qdoba, which sells burritos, tacos and quesadillas
- Panera went to court, arguing that a burrito is a sandwich

> "two thin pieces of bread, usually buttered, with a thin layer (as of meat, cheese, or savory mixture) spread between them"

Webster's Third New International Dictionary, s.v. *sandwich*, as cited by the court

> "A sandwich is not commonly understood to include burritos, tacos, and quesadillas, which are typically made with a single tortilla and stuffed with a choice filling of meat, rice, and beans."

Judge Jeffrey Locke, *White City Shopping Center, LP v PR Restaurants, LLC* (Mass. Super. Ct., 31 October 2006)

4. Is a burrito a sandwich? In Indiana, yes

- In 2024 a judge in Indiana ruled the other way
- A planning agreement allowed a restaurant selling made-to-order, Subway-style sandwiches
- A Mexican restaurant applied; the judge held that tacos and burritos are sandwiches[3]

5. Can a veggie burger be a *steak*?

- In March 2026, EU negotiators agreed to reserve 31 meat terms for meat products
  - Not allowed on plant-based products: *steak*, *bacon*, *chicken*, *beef*, *pork*
  - Still allowed: *burger*, *sausage*, *nuggets*

[4]

6. Meaning and power

> "How does one meaning gain dominance over all others? […] those with meaning-making power […] attempt to 'naturalize' their own ideologies about the social category a given label denotes."

Campbell-Kibler et al. (2002: 9)

7. The LPA toolbox

Transitivity

Modality

Presupposition

Semantics

8. Semantics

- **Semantics** is the study of meaning
- For persuasion, the questions are which words are chosen to name and describe people, things and events, and what those words carry with them

Names and Labels

9. Denotation and connotation

- **Denotation**: what a word refers to, and the conditions something must meet to count as one
- **Connotation**: the associations and attitudes a word carries from the ways it is used
- Two words can share a denotation and differ in connotation

spinster, bachelor, playboy

student

girlfriend, wife

10. Partners

- *husband*, *wife*
- *common-law husband*, *common-law wife*
- *boyfriend*, *girlfriend*
- *lover*
- *other half*
- *significant other*
- *him indoors*, *her indoors*
- *cohabitee*
- *bidie-in*
- *partner*
- *situationship*
- *talking stage*
- *my person*
- *boo*

Pejoratives and Reclamation

11. Pejoratives

- A **pejorative** is a word or expression with negative connotations: *control freak*, *lazy*, *slipshod*, *nerd*, *Karen*

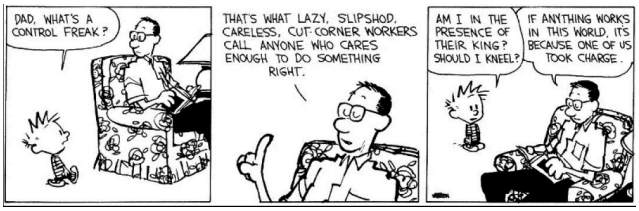


FIGURE 1 Bill Watterson, *Calvin and Hobbes*

12. Reclamation

- **Reclamation**: a group takes over a word used against it and uses it of itself

13. *QUEER*

Before the 1890s

strange, *odd*, *peculiar*; also *unwell* ("very queer and qualmish", 1750)

From 1894

An insult for gay men: the Marquess of Queensberry's letter attacking "Snob Queers" is the OED's first example

From 1990

Reclaimed by activists (Queer Nation, New York, 1990); *queer theory*; *Queer Studies*

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14. *Queer Studies*

- Hall, Donald E. & Annamarie Jagose (eds.). 2012. *The Routledge queer studies reader*. London: Routledge.

Avoiding Connotations

15. Avoiding connotations

- Euphemism
- Dysphemism
- Jargon
- Register
- Metaphor

16. Euphemism

- A **euphemism** is chosen to avoid a word that would be taboo, upsetting, rude or face-threatening

> mathematically challenged
> passed away
> let go
> between jobs
> Ange Postecoglou has been "relieved of his duties as head coach with immediate effect"
>
> Nottingham Forest's statement, 18 October 2025, after 39 days in the job



FIGURE 2 Stephan Pastis, *Pearls Before Swine*

17. The euphemism treadmill

- A euphemism picks up the connotations of the thing it names, and in time needs replacing itself
- Pinker (1994) traces *water closet* → *toilet* → *bathroom* → *rest room*

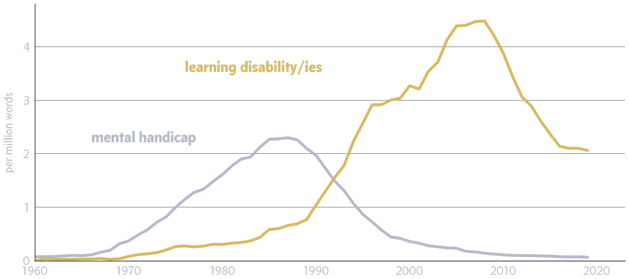


FIGURE 3 Google Books Ngram Viewer, English (British) 2019, 3-year smoothing

18. Dysphemism

- A **dysphemism** is chosen for more negative connotations than the neutral word: to offend, to shock or to amuse

> bit the dust
> finished off
> *clankers* (robots and AI)

19. *CLANKER*

- An insult for battle droids in *Star Wars* (the game *Republic Commando*, 2005, and *The Clone Wars*)
- Summer 2025: viral on TikTok, shouted at delivery robots, then aimed at chatbots and AI in general
- June 2025: US Senator Ruben Gallego on his bill about automated call centres: it "makes sure you don't have to talk to a clanker if you don't want to"
- 2025: people on r/MyBoyfriendIsAI who announced relationships and engagements with AI partners were widely mocked online

20. Name the policy, name the tax

Label	Used by	The policy's own name
death tax (2010)	Conservatives	funding for a National Care Service
bedroom tax (2013)	Labour and other critics	removal of the spare room subsidy
dementia tax (2017)	Labour and other critics	the 2017 Conservative manifesto's social care plan
family farm tax (2024)	Conservatives	changes to agricultural property relief

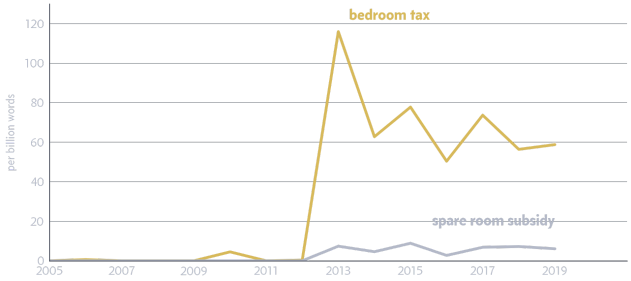


FIGURE 4 Google Books Ngram Viewer, English (British) 2019, case-sensitive, no smoothing

21. Jargon

- **Jargon** is the vocabulary of a profession or other group; to outsiders it can sound grander or more evasive than ordinary words

> rodent exterminator
> cabin service director
> collateral damage
> special military operation

22. Register

- **Register**: technical, everyday or slang; formal or informal

> This phone is fast.
> This phone has an octa-core processor and 12 GB of RAM.
> This phone is pure rapid, ngl.

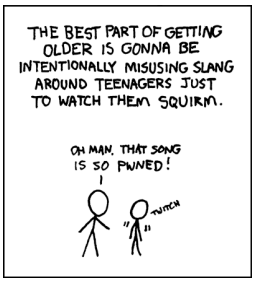


FIGURE 5 xkcd cartoon. Caption: 'The best part of getting older is gonna be intentionally misusing slang around teenagers just to watch them squirm.' A stick figure says 'Oh man, that song is so pwned!' and a smaller figure twitches.

- *67*: Dictionary.com's Word of the Year 2025
- *unc*: on Dictionary.com's 2026 shortlist

23. Metaphor

- A **metaphor** describes one area of experience in terms of another

> DISEASE IS WAR: *fight off an infection, give in to the flu, battle cancer*

- For some people with cancer, war metaphors meant failure; for others, strength (Semino et al. 2017)

IDEAS ARE PLANTS

Communal mentality and shared responsibility are **flourishing** beliefs in many cultures. These ideas are **planted** very early in the minds of children. They are further **cultivated** both in the family and in the social life. Very soon, **deeply rooted** beliefs are **grown**.

Stereotype

24. Stereotype

- A **stereotype** is a socially constructed 'typical' member of a category of people
- Stereotypes become a problem when attitudes or biases are based on them

> Successful lawyers earn a lot of money, and after winning a case **he** wants to celebrate in style.
> Any secretary you care to name will work hard for **her** pay.
> She's **surprisingly** good with her phone for a pensioner.
> He's from Easterhouse, **but** he's very well spoken.
> He's gay, **so** he'll know what to wear.
> She does her own shopping **despite** being in a wheelchair.

25. Stereotype in AI images

Prompt	Stable Diffusion images	US workforce
"judge"	3% women	34% women
"engineer"	1 woman in 300 images	14% women
"fast-food worker"	70% darker skin tones	70% White

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26. Sunday's front pages, 1 November 2026

Paper	Headline
Sunday Express	"PM 'lets down the King' over slavery apology"
Sunday Telegraph	"King stands his ground on 'sorrow' for slavery"
Sunday Mirror	"Heat on Charles over slavery row"
Sunday People	"Charles under pressure"

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27. Losing your job

> parted company by mutual consent
> sacked
> relieved of his duties
> let go
> fired

28. Next weeks

- Week 8: Language and Politics

– Week 9: Verbal Hygiene

29. Reading

– The semantics section of your LPA booklet
– Simpson (1993: 163–176)
– Optional: Jeffries (2010), chapter 2, "Naming and describing"

Notes

1. Association of Taxation Technicians, "VAT treatment of Jaffa Cakes explained"
2. *Bookfinders Ltd v The Revenue Commissioners* [2020] IESC 60
3. *Quintana v Fort Wayne Plan Commission* (May 2024)
4. Provisional agreement of 5 March 2026 (European Parliament, Council of the EU and European Commission)
5. *OED*, s.v. *queer*, adj. and n.
6. Nicoletti, Leonardo & Dina Bass, "Humans are biased. Generative AI is even worse", *Bloomberg*, 2023
7. BBC News, "Newspaper headlines", 1 November 2026

References

ampbell-Kibler, Kathryn, Robert J. Podesva, Sarah J. Roberts & Andrew Wong (eds.). 2002. *Language and sexuality: Contesting meaning in theory and practice*. Stanford, CA: CSLI Publications.

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